

MEDIAN

PHILOSOPHICAL ARCHITECTURE

The Attachment-Forward Colony Game

MEDIAN is an animal-colony base-building game set in the living median strips of active highways.

Build one permanent sanctuary. Send named Citizens beyond its safety. Bring consequence home. Remember what happened.

A top-level doctrine of genre, sanctuary, citizenship, place, risk, memory, Modes, and Registers.

DESIGN PHILOSOPHY • DOCUMENT v2.0

I. THE GAME IN ONE BREATH

A civilization where nobody else would call home

MEDIAN is a game about creating, endangering, experiencing, and remembering sanctuary.

A small animal civilization makes a permanent settlement in the median strip between active highway carriageways. The player builds and tends that settlement, sends named animals beyond its safety, answers the situations they meet, and brings discoveries, materials, relationships, wounds, and memories back home.

The settlement is called the Home Median. The community living there is the Colony. Every named member of that community is a Citizen. Mouse, Rabbit, and Squirrel colonies build distinct forms of civilization; animals from other species may also be welcomed as equal Citizens.

The two basic conditions of play

Mode	Plain-language meaning	What the player does
HOME MODE	The Colony is in its permanent settlement.	Build, tend, organize, understand, and live with the Colony.
AWAY MODE	Named Citizens have left the safety of Home.	Cross roads, travel the corridor, meet the wider world, and bring things and consequences back.

The game’s central dramatic promise is not conquest. It is return. Home matters because someone may have to leave it; leaving matters because it changes particular lives; and those changes remain present when the road becomes warm, close, and familiar again.

SANCTUARY → EXPOSURE → CONSEQUENCE → RETURN → MEMORY

II. A READER MAP

Modes say where life is; Registers say how the player meets it

MEDIAN uses a small formal vocabulary. Every term is introduced here before the document relies on it.

A **Mode** is one of the game's two broad conditions: Home or Away. A **Register** is a distinct form of play inside those conditions. Each Register has a characteristic action, pace, kind of decision, and indicative camera view.

Register	Plain-language action	Mode	Indicative camera shorthand
DWELL	Build and tend the Colony.	Home	Elevated three-quarter real-time strategy view, broadly comparable to Age of Empires.
TRAVEL	Move through and read extended territory.	Away	Illustrated corridor survey, route map, or 2.5D travel view.
RISK	Act inside immediate spatial danger.	Away	Committed action view shaped by traffic, timing, and bodily vulnerability.
MEET	Answer a bounded situation with consequential choice.	Home or Away	Staged close tableau showing participants, place, and stakes.
EMBODY	Experience ordinary animal life made possible by a safe Home.	Home	Intimate guided third-person, tactile motion, or sensory close view.

The camera language is shorthand, not a production prison. A manifestation may translate a Register through boards, cards, narration, touch, or a different camera while preserving the same relationship between player and world.

Home Mode is where you build and tend the Colony. Away Mode is where you send Citizens out of the safety of Home to bring something back.

One world persists beneath every Register. The same Citizen, Place, route, object, weather condition, promise, or memory may be seen from different distances and resolved through different forms of play without becoming a different world.

III. THE INVENTED GENRE

The attachment-forward base builder

Attachment is not an ornamental reward. It is the direction in which the design points.

Most base builders treat the settlement primarily as a machine, a shield, or a platform for expansion. MEDIAN treats the base as an inhabited social protagonist: one place whose systems make named lives legible and worth returning to. The Colony is not consumed by progression. Progress accumulates around it.

Orientation	The base is understood as...	Success tends toward...
Production-forward	A machine whose parts generate throughput.	Acceleration, efficiency, expansion, and replacement.
Survival-forward	A defensive apparatus holding collapse at bay.	Continued existence, recovery, and postponement of disaster.
Attachment-forward	A particular inhabited place with particular lives and history.	Stable ordinary life, accumulated meaning, and chosen risk on behalf of what matters.

The four anchors of attachment

A strong system usually strengthens one or more of four relationships:

- Home — the permanent place the player has made, learned, and returned to.
- Citizen — a named life with prior history, present relationships, and possible future.
- Place or object — a material thing whose use and provenance become particular.
- Memory — a fact that persists because it mattered, not because it grants a modifier.

The mechanics are arranged so that the player always has someone and somewhere to come back to.

The attachment chain

LEGIBILITY → COMPETENCE → STABILITY → ATTENTION → ATTACHMENT
ATTACHMENT → CHOSEN RISK → CONSEQUENCE → RETURN → DEEPER ATTACHMENT

Mechanical rigor and tenderness are not opposites. A Colony that never becomes comprehensible cannot become beloved. A Colony that never becomes stable cannot be inhabited emotionally. The design must first fill the player's need for Game Logic; only then can attention open toward ordinary lives, familiar Places, and accumulated memory.

IV. THE EIGHT GLOBAL PILLARS

What every major system must continue to serve

Pillars are game-wide tests. A system may emphasize some more than others, but none may casually contradict them.

1. Attachment-forward base-building

The Home Median is the permanent emotional and mechanical center of the campaign. It is improved, densified, decorated, damaged, repaired, inhabited, and remembered rather than replaced. Corridor growth creates a network around Home; it does not turn Home into an obsolete tutorial settlement.

2. Named Citizens, low population, durable identity

Every Citizen is individually known. Population remains small enough for every name to count. Core species and Guest origins share one equal class of citizenship. Loss, bravery, habit, relationship, disability, inheritance, and prior life matter because Citizens are companions and community members, not replenishable unit tokens.

3. Ledger and legible

Important state should first be perceptible in the world and also available in clear functional form. MEDIAN rejects both opaque sentiment and spreadsheet abstraction. The player should understand what is known, what is uncertain, and why a decision matters without reducing every personal truth to a public number.

Atmosphere is not an excuse for obscurity. Legibility is what lets the player make a place their own.

IV. THE EIGHT GLOBAL PILLARS — CONTINUED

Growth, consequence, and the conservation of systems

4. Home grows the Colony; Away grows the Citizen

Home develops collective capability: Places, Practices, reserves, settlement form, culture, readiness, and civic continuity. Away develops particular Citizens through exposure, equipment, relationships, knowledge, wounds, Distinctions, and remembered acts. Expeditions make stories and enable progress because return causes these two forms of growth to alter one another.

Home grows the Colony. Away grows and hazards Citizens. Return makes each answer the other.

5. Consequence without disposability

Danger changes lives before it erases them. Fear, wounds, Maiming, Distinctions, Keepsakes, After-names, separation, and altered relationships carry consequence home. Death remains possible, but the game does not treat Citizens as expendable inputs or convert their loss into routine inventory management.

6. Conservation of Systems

Fit new mechanics into existing systems wherever possible. New meaning should preferentially arise through manifestation, context, permission, combination, species interpretation, memory, or promotion of an existing rule—not through another meter, currency, menu, progression track, or exception procedure.

Conservation is not minimalism for its own sake. It creates a small grammar that the player can understand deeply while the world continues to produce expressive variety. Tabletop clarity sits beneath lived civilization.

IV. THE EIGHT GLOBAL PILLARS — CONTINUED

Unity of world and the precondition for attachment

7. One world, two Modes, five Registers

DWELL, TRAVEL, RISK, MEET, and EMBODY are not separate games. They are five relationships to one persistent world, distributed across Home and Away. The same Citizen, Place, object, route, weather, wound, promise, or memory may appear differently in each. Transitions are emotional beats, not neutral load screens.

8. Game Logic creates Attachment Space

Attachment space cannot open until Game Logic space has been satisfied. The player must understand the Colony, make sound decisions, and believe that safety has been mechanically achieved before the game can reasonably ask them to linger, observe, remember, or care.

This is not an argument for cold systems followed by decorative sentiment. It is a causal sequence: legibility enables competence; competence enables stability; stability releases attention; attention makes attachment possible.

The player must first believe the game before they can emotionally inhabit it.

Corollary: every substantial module must do Game Logic work

Pure narrative texture may exist simply to enrich the world. Any module that asks the player for sustained attention, choice, preparation, or repeated use must also have a real logical function. It must change what can be understood, chosen, risked, protected, built, remembered, or brought home. Sentiment unsupported by game logic feels ornamental; game logic that never releases attention leaves no room for sentiment.

V. SECOND-TIER GUIDING PRINCIPLES

Binding doctrines within particular domains

Guiding Principles rank below the Global Pillars. They are not tests for every system; they govern one domain of design. Their compact forms often function as design aphorisms: a short sentence that resolves ambiguity without creating a new subsystem.

Level	Scope	Use
Global Pillar	The whole game	Every major system must continue to serve it.
Guiding Principle	One domain	Resolves design choices inside Citizenship, Home, Away, MEET, Memory, or presentation.
Aphorism	A recurring judgment	A compact statement that keeps the larger principle easy to apply.

Citizenship and identity

- All Citizens are classed alike. Core and Guest species use one equal Citizen architecture.
- Arrival does not create personhood. Every named arrival already belongs to a prior life.
- A Home Role is a civic assignment, not a character class, caste, or aptitude ranking.
- Identity may matter without producing a modifier. Habit, grief, relationship, memory, and provenance do not require a buff to justify persistence.

Home

- The Colony is the Home crunch subject. Citizens contribute equal, named shares of civic commitment.
- Good Home play produces successful stillness: a real plateau in which ordinary life can continue without constant intervention.
- Persistent capacities remain global; acute consequences become situated in a particular Place, household, relationship, or scene.
- Ordinary life is not idle production capacity. Rest, conversation, play, and familiar routine are parts of civilization, not wasted throughput.

V. SECOND-TIER GUIDING PRINCIPLES — CONTINUED

Away, choice, and group resolution

Away

- The Citizen is the Away crunch subject. Equipment, bodily difference, fear, history, and consequence resolve through particular lives.
- Most Citizens come home; not all come home unchanged. Danger should first produce legible consequence rather than routine disposability.
- Withdrawal remains meaningful. The player may preserve lives by yielding an objective rather than being forced into all-or-nothing heroics.
- No irreversible personal loss should occur off-screen. The player must be present when a named life is permanently changed or lost.

Choice over incidental outcome

Consequential play should center on what the player chooses to protect, risk, spend, accept, or relinquish. Randomness and simulation may shape the world, but important consequences should not feel like trivia that happened while the player was looking elsewhere.

Encounter group resolution

The expedition party answers an Encounter together. The player chooses the group's approach; the scene may then follow one Citizen as the temporary protagonist of that choice. This temporary protagonist is called Focus.

The party resolves the Encounter. Focus decides whose life the moment belongs to.

Focus is a following mechanic. It arises because the chosen approach, Tool, Keepsake, or authored circumstance makes one Citizen the natural protagonist. Focus never creates an Encounter option merely so that a preferred Citizen can lead it.

V. SECOND-TIER GUIDING PRINCIPLES — CONTINUED

Memory, objects, care, and presentation

Memory

- History persists because it mattered, not because it grants a bonus.
- The Chronicle records selected civic history; each Citizen's Tale preserves the shape of one life.
- Campaign Memory supplies continuity across Modes and Registers without turning every remembered event into progression.
- Ephemerality is permitted. A quiet moment may be valuable without entering a permanent log.

Objects and attachment

- Persistent named objects are simple to use but not entirely anonymous.
- Tools express ordinary capability and assumed identity; Keepsakes express personal meaning; Special Artifacts express civic history.
- Provenance and consequential use create attachment more reliably than rarity tiers or numerical upgrades.

Care

- Care must not collapse into a buff economy. The player should sometimes attend to a Citizen because that life matters.
- A Citizen retains expressive ownership. The player may accompany, prepare, choose, and protect, but cannot command affection or exact emotion.

Presentation

- Camera expresses the player's relationship to the world; it is not merely a zoom level.
- Folk meaning and functional truth should remain visible together.
- The world should be atmospheric without hiding its operation.
- The interface should present meaningful available choices rather than displaying every theoretically possible action.

VI. MODES AND REGISTERS

Two conditions of play; five forms of attention

Home Mode

Home Mode is where the player builds and tends the Colony in its permanent Home Median. The player places and improves the settlement, assigns civic responsibility, prepares for seasons and expeditions, resolves domestic situations, and spends time with the lives made possible by a functioning sanctuary.

Away Mode

Away Mode is where the player sends named Citizens out of the safety of Home to cross roads, travel the corridor, discover resources and communities, answer danger and obligation, and bring materials, knowledge, relationships, objects, and consequences back to the Colony.

Mode	Primary subject	Primary action	What can grow
HOME	The Colony	Build, tend, organize, prepare, and inhabit.	Places, Practices, reserves, culture, readiness, population, and collective capability.
AWAY	Particular Citizens and the expedition party	Cross, travel, meet, choose, endure, and return.	Experience, equipment, relationships, knowledge, wounds, Distinctions, and personal history.

The five Registers

A Register is a distinct form of play. It tells the player what kind of attention is required now. The associated camera is indicative shorthand: it helps communicate the intended relation, but the Register is defined by action and dramatic function rather than by one mandatory lens.

Register	Verb	Mode	Player relationship	Indicative camera
Colony	DWELL	Home	Build, tend, and understand collective life.	Elevated three-quarter RTS view, broadly comparable to Age of Empires. The Colony is read as one inhabited landscape; DWELL is not a sectional cutaway.
Field	TRAVEL	Away	Carry particular lives through extended territory.	Naturalist survey, illustrated route plate, or 2.5D corridor view.
Crossing	RISK	Away	Preserve life inside immediate spatial danger.	Committed action view organized by traffic, refuge, timing, burden, and motion.
Encounter	MEET	Home or Away	Answer a bounded circumstance with consequential choice.	Staged close tableau showing the actual participants, place, and threatened values.
Embodiment	EMBODY	Home	Experience ordinary animal life freed from immediate necessity.	Intimate guided third-person, tactile motion, or sensory cinematic.

Danger makes sanctuary necessary. DWELL makes sanctuary functional. EMBODY makes sanctuary felt. Memory makes sanctuary personal.

VII. MEET

The universal situation-and-choice resolver

MEET is the moment when a condition in the world becomes a choice the player must answer.

MEET is cross-modal. A Colony may meet heavy wind, illness, floodwater, a dispute, a stranger, or a threatened Place. An expedition may meet a blocked route, predator, community, resource, demand, injury, or unexpected obligation. “Meeting” does not require two opposing characters; it means that a bounded circumstance has become consequential enough to deserve the player’s judgment.

Why one resolver matters

MEET is a central expression of Conservation of Systems. MEDIAN does not require separate primary subsystems for negotiation, predation, storms, civic disputes, resource opportunities, structural failure, hospitality, and rescue. They share a common grammar of visible stakes, constrained choices, cost, consequence, and remembered aftermath.

The choice is the center

A MEET scene should ask what the Colony or party will protect, pursue, surrender, spend, reinterpret, or accept. It is not a broad tactical command bar and not a combat engine with peaceful scenes reskinned around it. Violence may occur, but the underlying question remains how a group answers a situation.

Source	Example circumstance	What the choice concerns
Home	Heavy winds threaten a roofline and exposed stores.	Which value receives scarce civic attention, and what consequence is accepted elsewhere?
Away	A stranger controls access to a needed route.	What relationship, obligation, resource, or risk will the party accept?
Away	An uncontested food source is larger than the party can safely carry.	What is harvested, what is left, and how much return burden is chosen?
Home	A newcomer’s arrival exposes a disagreement inside the Colony.	How belonging, hospitality, memory, and limited capacity are reconciled.

Group action; personal history

The Colony or expedition resolves the situation collectively. Focus may follow one Citizen for a particular choice, allowing the camera, action, and eventual Tale to become personal without turning MEET into a series of individual skill checks. The group answers the world; particular lives carry what happened.

VIII. SPECIES PERSONALITY AND SPATIAL PREFERENCE

Three civilizations built from three bodily ideas of safety

Mouse, Rabbit, and Squirrel are not cosmetic factions or alternate stat packages. Each body reads the same median differently. Those bodily preferences become settlement form, movement style, social expectation, hospitality, vulnerability, and cultural personality.

BODY → PERCEPTION OF SAFETY → SPATIAL PREFERENCE → CIVILIZATIONAL PERSONALITY

Species	Placement verb	Bodily idea of safety	Spatial and social personality	Civilizational promise
Mouse	JOIN	Contact, enclosure, adjacency, and continuous passage.	Domestic accumulation; attached rooms; short covered links; shared walls; inward warmth; the sense that many lives belong to one inhabited body.	There is room for you under our roof.
Rabbit	GATHER	Mutual visibility, shared ground, nearby concealment, and collective movement.	Neighborhood life; courts and greens; entrances facing common space; social openness held against protective edges.	We will make another neighborhood for you.
Squirrel	CONNECT	Reachability, elevated refuge, alternate routes, and non-isolated nodes.	Route-minded civilization; platforms, bridges, caches, junctions, redundancy, lookout, and confidence across separation.	We will bring you into reach.

Species personality is more than architecture

JOIN, GATHER, and CONNECT influence how each civilization imagines privacy, care, council, storage, hospitality, warning, celebration, grief, and expansion. Spatial preference becomes cultural metaphor. A Mouse promise sounds like enclosure and belonging; a Rabbit promise sounds like neighborhood and company; a Squirrel promise sounds like route and reach.

DWELL representation

DWELL uses an elevated three-quarter strategy camera. Mouse Manor Houses are therefore above-ground joined compounds whose exterior massing makes continuity visible. They are not literal underground sections. Rabbit courts read through shared open ground and surrounding entrances. Squirrel Webs read through separated nodes connected by visible, preferably redundant routes.

Ecology suggests what safety feels like. Civilization decides what to build, remember, and promise from it.

IX. THE WORLD, ITS TONE, AND THE PLAYER

Modern infrastructure, animal-scale civilization

The highway is not scenery

MEDIAN takes place inside active human infrastructure, not after its abandonment. Traffic, maintenance, noise, runoff, heat, salt, wind, vibration, barriers, drainage, verge growth, and human work continually reorganize animal life. The highway is barrier, climate, resource edge, and ecological organizer at once.

The Median is therefore a moral and spatial paradox: a strip designed as nobody’s destination becomes a permanent polity. Human scale remains vast, mostly indifferent, and only partly legible. The animals do not conquer that world or reproduce it in miniature. They make a non-industrial scrap culture inside its seams.

The tonal balance

MEDIAN seeks...	Rather than...
Sanctuary	“Cozy” safety detached from credible material and social conditions.
Peril	Combat fantasy or heroic violence as the primary solution.
Civilization	Miniature human industrialization, electricity fantasy, factory chains, or medieval adventurer society.
Tenderness	Sentimentality that demands a buff, reward, or compulsory emotional response.
Legibility	A spreadsheet that hides the inhabited world behind menus.
Quiet	Emptiness, inactivity, or the absence of meaningful play.

The player’s position

The player is not principally a commander, mayor, production optimizer, or possessed avatar. The player moves among several ethical positions:

- Steward — arrange finite civic attention so the Colony can function and become safe.
- Chooser — decide when a need or ambition justifies sending particular friends beyond sanctuary.
- Witness — remain present when consequence belongs to a named life rather than an abstract unit.
- Companion — in EMBODY, accompany rather than possess; guide attention while the Citizen retains expression.
- Rememberer — preserve what mattered without converting every emotional fact into advantage.

X. DESIGN PROTECTIONS

Guardrails for keeping MEDIAN itself

- Protect attachment chains. Feature density is not progress unless a new element strengthens Home, a Citizen, a Place or object, or accumulated memory.
- Make quiet mechanically credible. Endless entropy prevents the player from noticing the life they are protecting.
- Protect player attention. Use comprehensible accounting, compressed state, and situated scenes rather than continuous alarm management.
- Keep Home collective and Away particular. Do not import productivity aptitude into Home or flatten Away consequence into anonymous party math.
- Use existing grammar before inventing a subsystem. Conservation of Systems is the default response to new content.
- Care must not become an optimization chore. Meaning is allowed to remain non-instrumental.
- Comparability is useful; convergence is not automatically progress. A familiar genre convention must be tested against what it would erase.

Compact doctrine

Doctrine	Canonical statement
Pitch	Animal-colony base building on active highway median strips.
Genre	Attachment-forward base builder.
Home	Build and tend one permanent Colony until ordinary life can genuinely continue.
Away	Send named Citizens beyond sanctuary to bring something and someone changed back.
Growth	Home grows the Colony; Away grows and hazards Citizens.
Systems	Conserve mechanics; multiply meaning through context, manifestation, and memory.
Logic	Game Logic must be satisfied before Attachment Space can open.
Citizenship	All Citizens are classed alike; arrival does not create personhood.
Choice	Choice over incidental outcome; group resolution with personal consequence.
Modes	Home and Away are the two broad conditions of play.
Registers	DWELL, TRAVEL, RISK, MEET, and EMBODY are five forms of attention inside one world.
Species	Mouse JOINS, Rabbit GATHERS, and Squirrel CONNECTs because their bodies understand safety differently.
Memory	What mattered may persist without becoming a modifier.
Success	Good Home play produces successful stillness.

Closing proposition

MEDIAN is a base builder in which the highest achievement is not a larger machine but a more inhabited world. Its systems exist to make sanctuary credible, danger personal, return consequential, and memory cumulative. The player should finish a campaign not merely knowing what was built, but knowing who lived there, what the place became, who left it, who returned, and why the quiet was worth earning.

BUILD A SANCTUARY. HAZARD PARTICULAR FRIENDS. BRING CONSEQUENCE HOME. REMEMBER WHAT HAPPENED.